Bad Press Day



Two aggrieved women, both mothers who had lost their children in the 2024 Harni Lake boat tragedy, interrupted Gujarat CM **Bhupendra Patel** at a public event in Vadodara on May 2. They wanted justice, were forcibly removed for their pains, but with the cameras rolling, the video quickly went viral. Patel made the right noises and also met them later, but sources say he was miffed, not just over the lapses that had brought the women to this point of despair but also for the heavy-handed manner they were dealt with in full glare of the media.

PACKERS AND MOVERS



Maharashtra CM **Devendra Fadnavis** took over in December 2024, but his not moving into official residence 'Varsha' had led to many a theory, including the opposition Shiv Sena UBT charge of 'black magic rituals' by its last occupant, ex-CM Eknath Shinde, who has been relegated to playing second fiddle in the current government. However, Fadnavis has now put all speculation to rest; he moved into 'Varsha' on April 30, Akshaya Tritiya day.

HOME TRUTHS



Political strategist-turned-neta **Prashant Kishor,** the man credited with Nitish Kumar's 2015 victory and now the CM's harshest critic, has declared that "clarity begins at home". He is, of course, talking about Nitish's home in Kalyanbigha, the CM's ancestral village in Nalanda. On May 11, Kishor is launching a door-to-door campaign here to see if Nitish's flagship promises for the poor have come through. Things seem to be cutting a tad too close to home for Nitish babu.

Kaushik Deka with Arkamoy Datta Majumdar, Ajay Sukumaran, Amitabh Srivastava, Jumana Shah and Dhaval S. Kulkarni

ECO WATCH

SPOTS OF CHEER



ANI

Mumbai is seeing a leap of leopards. Literally. Leopard numbers in its green lung—the Sanjay Gandhi National Park or the Borivali National Park—have grown since the last count in 2018. From 47 leopards then, 54 cats are now roaming the 198.34 sq. km expanse of the park.

The cats were tracked from February-June 2024 using camera traps at 90 locations in SGNP, Aarey Milk Colony and the Tungareshwar Wildlife Sanctuary. A joint survey by the Maharashtra forest department and the Wildlife Conservation Society India, its recent report identified 54 leopards—36 females, 16 males and two 'unidentified cats'. Interestingly, three females first captured on camera in 2015 were 're-captured' in 2024, indicating a healthy survival rate.

SPECIES ALERT
MANIS INDOBURMANICA

Don't let that scientific name alarm you. It's just a new species of the Pangolin, the scaly anteater whose burrowing skills make it the 'ecosystem's engineer'. It may look like a dinky dinosaur but is really a mammal, not a reptile. India discovered the distinct species this January in Arunachal. Geoclimatic changes seem to have spurred its genetic departure from its Chinese ancestor 3.4 million years ago. It will add to the eight species of pangolins worldwide, and be the third to be found in India. It has a pinkish face, and its dark/olive brown scales distinguish it from the yellow brown-scaled Indian and Chinese pangolins. Prized for its scales and meat, pangolin trafficking is rife. And protection a priority.

